



1. What is a union?
2. The business of architecture
3. Band-aids or structural change?
4. Collective solutions to common problems

What is a union?

Work before unions



Work became mass-scaled in the industrial revolution

There was a sharper distinction between owners and worker

Workers had long days and no rights

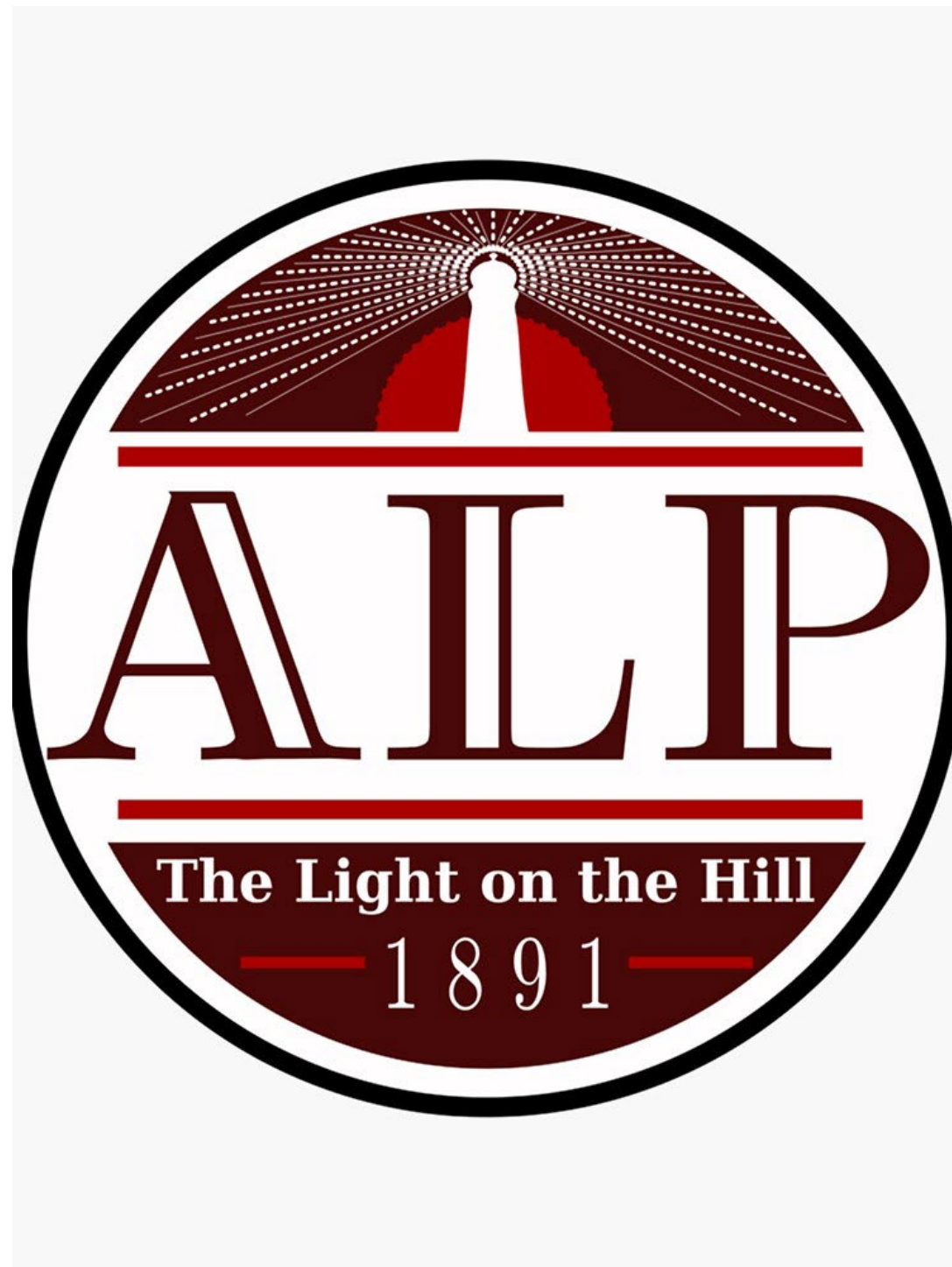
Major achievements of unions



in the 19th century, workers started to organise and demand better

The weekend and 8 hour work day are relatively new concepts

Workplace safety laws, industrial awards and collective agreements protect workers

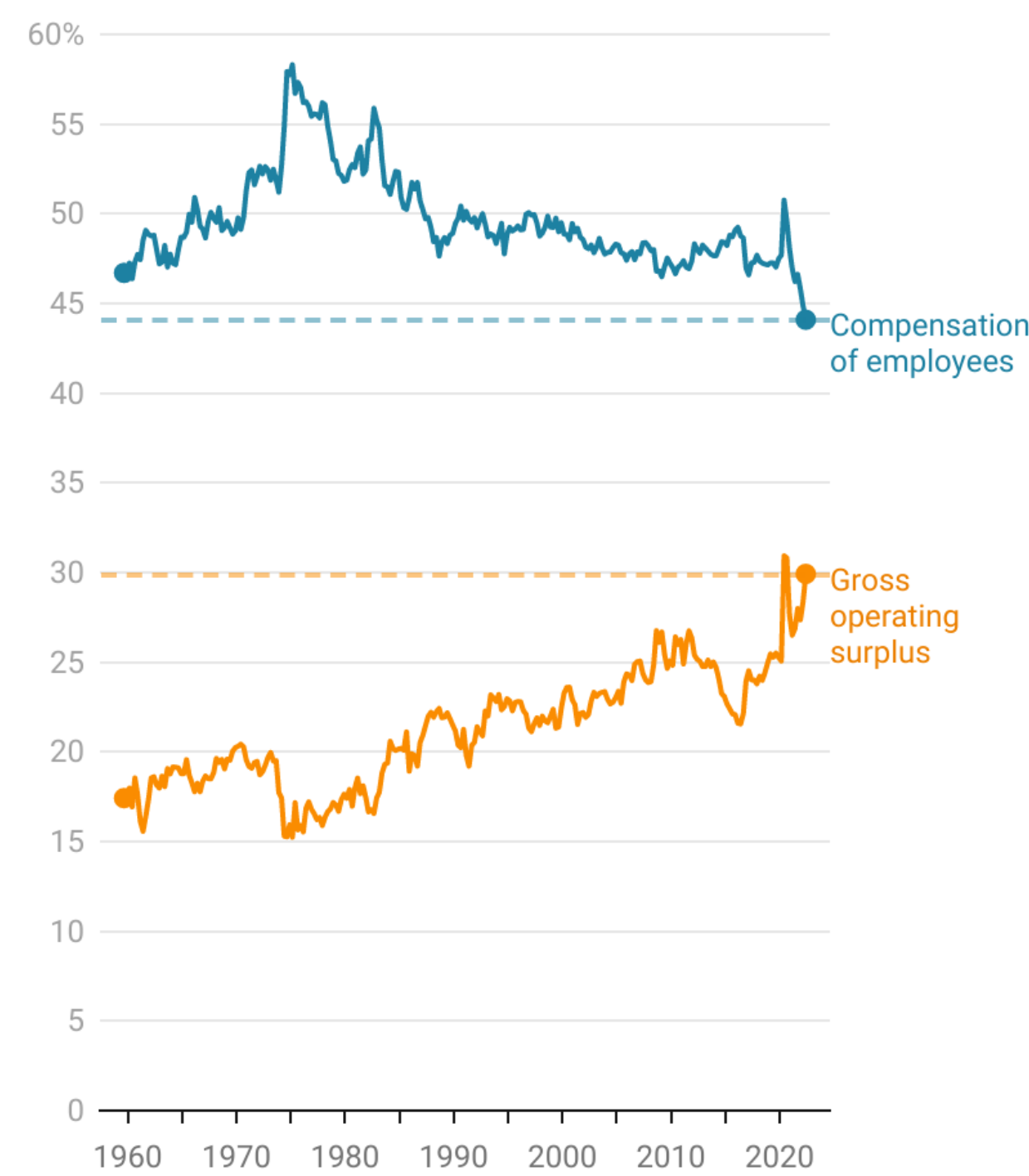


Unions produced their own political parties, formed governments and made laws

Businesses fought back with their own political parties and media

Unions are fundamentally democratic

Union density and wage stagnation



- Laws have been designed to punish unions
- Membership density has declined, as intended
- Corporate profits have risen as worker pay has stagnated

The current role of unions

13. Minimum rates

[Varied by [PR718897](#), [PR729338](#), [PR740763](#), [PR762188](#), [PR767683](#), [PR773966](#), [PR780220](#), [PR786618](#), [PR799359](#)]

13.1 Minimum rates

[13.1 varied by [PR718897](#), [PR729338](#), [PR740763](#), [PR762188](#), [PR773966](#), [PR786618](#), [PR799359](#) ppc 01Jul26]

The minimum rates payable for employment in the occupation of an architect or upon work of a kind which would normally be performed by an architect must be:

Classification	Minimum annual rate (full-time employees)	Minimum weekly rate (full-time employee)	Minimum hourly rate (full-time, part-time and casual employees)
	\$	\$	\$
Level 1—Graduate of Architecture			
Entry	68,191	1307.20	34.40
1st pay point	71,798	1376.30	36.22
2nd pay point	75,401	1445.40	38.04
Level 2(a)—Experienced Graduate of Architecture			
Experienced Graduate of Architecture	78,838	1511.30	39.77
Level 2(b)—Registered Architect			
Entry	78,838	1511.30	39.77
1st pay point	81,276	1558.00	41.00



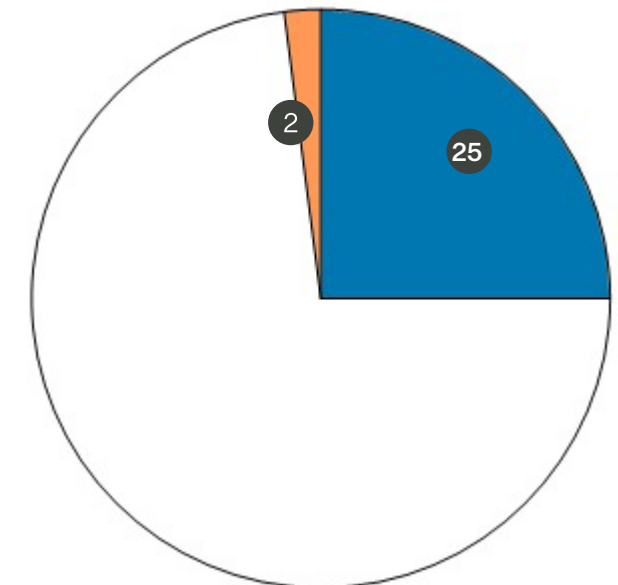
Unions cover all workers - UAW is the union for architects

We protect individual workers when their employer does the wrong thing

We also fight for structural change, for example at fair work or through EBAs

The business of architecture

Development for profit

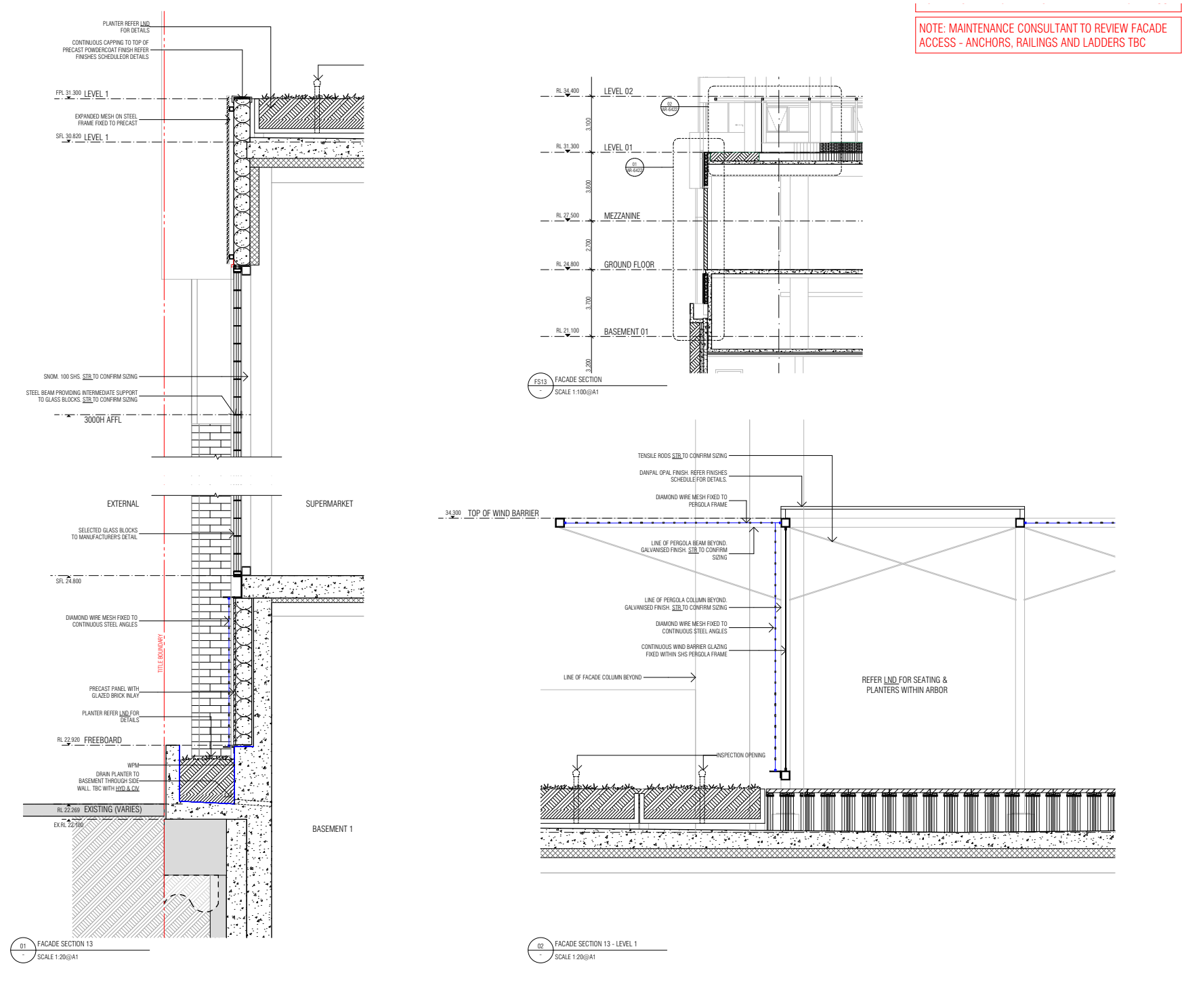


We may be motivated by good design or community benefit

Developers are motivated by profit - 20-30% is the target range

Architects' fees on large projects are about 2% of construction cost

Salaries vs fees



Fees are charged per hour of your time spent

The charge-out rate is generally 4x your salary

Architectural firms target 20% profit - for every dollar you earn, your boss makes about the same

Owners and workers



Small practices sometimes describe themselves as 'family'

In reality there are a small number of business owners and a large number of workers

It is in workers' best interests to see themselves as workers and make sure they are getting fair pay and conditions

The race to the bottom

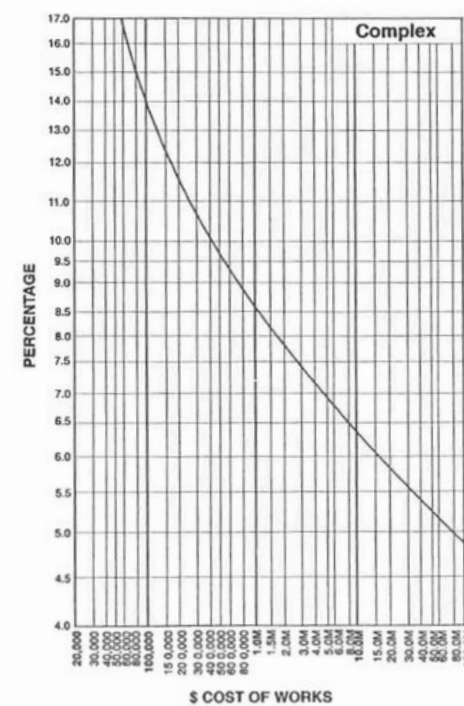
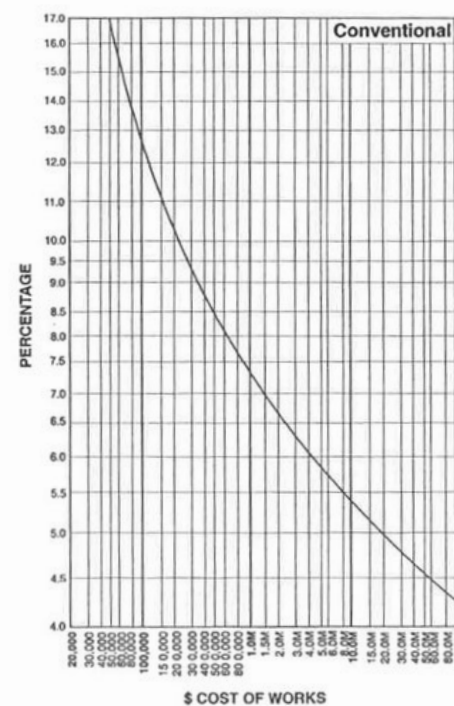
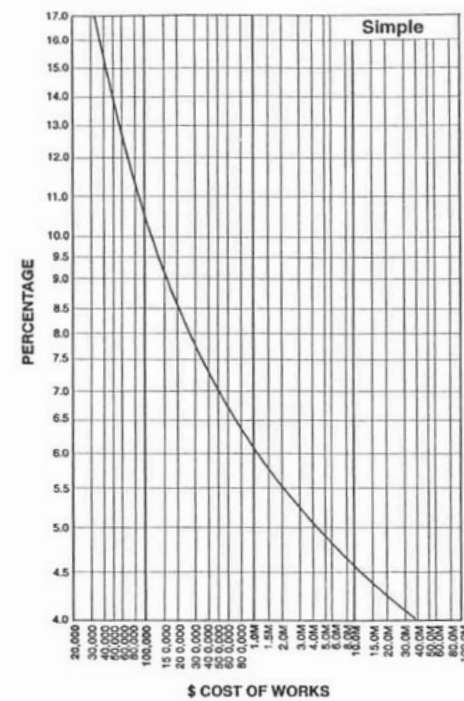
AN02.03.100 July 2001

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These graphs indicate a fee for continuous service consisting of schematic design, design development, contract documentation, tendering and negotiating and contract administration.

They allow for adequate expenditure on professional development, marketing, salaries at commercial rates and investment in new technologies.

They allow for a commercial rate of profit.



There used to be architectural fee scales - a fixed minimum - but this was considered 'anti-competitive' and abolished

Now the fee could be \$0 - and there is always someone out there desperate for the work

Firms cannot solve this problem, as they are in competition with each other. They take turn being the one desperate enough to 'buy' the work.

Exploitation



When a firm agrees to a low fee, someone will pay the price - usually the most junior workers

Unpaid overtime is wage theft - and wage theft is a crime. Yet it is common

It exacerbates already low rates of pay, so people burn out and leave the profession

Band-aids or structural change?

Symptoms of an unwell profession

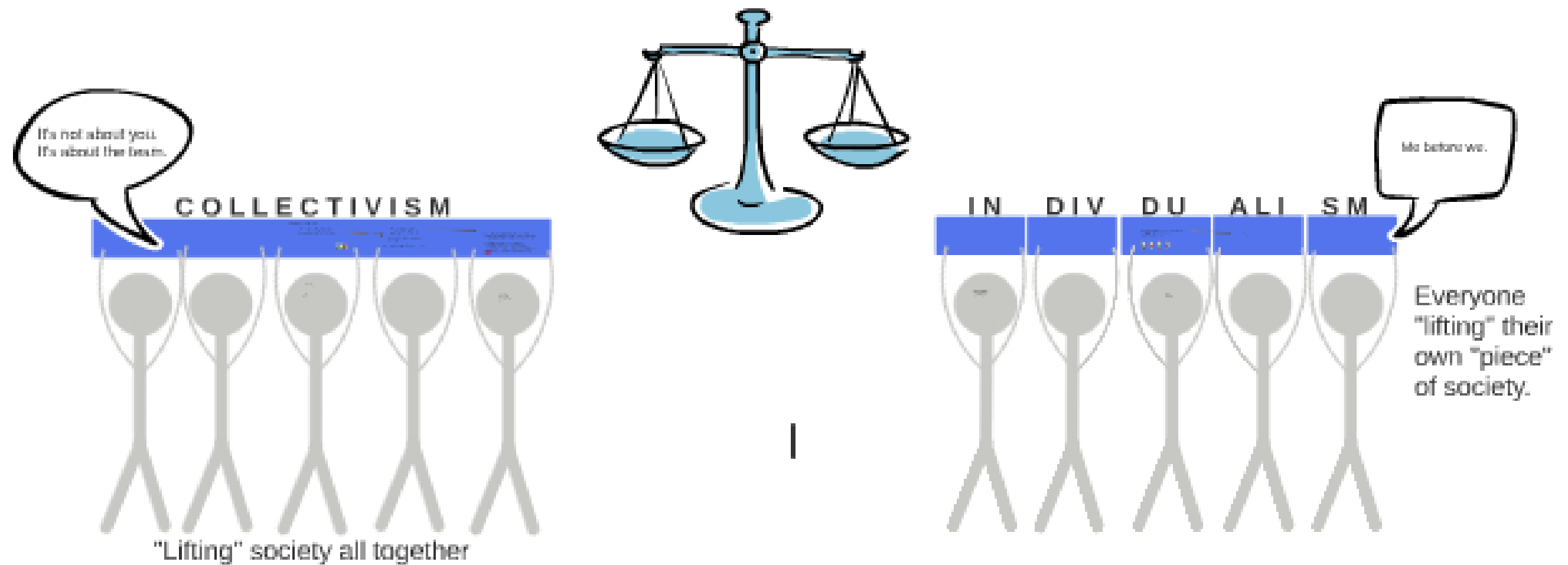


The things you complain about at Friday night drinks aren't just something you have to put up with

Architects' Wellbeing research has shown what we already knew anecdotally in large scale data

Architects are overworked, underpaid, and it makes us unwell

Limits of individual action



Individuals try to fix their own problem by changing their job - but the new workplace is in the same system with the same incentives

In America the 'temporarily embarrassed millionaire' argues against taxing the rich because they think it will be them one day - Some architects think they are a 'temporarily embarrassed director' - that their status as a worker is temporary - and don't advocate for themselves properly

We as a union can protect individuals against the system's excesses
- but even better is to fix the problems with the system



13. As such, there does not appear to be any concerns around gender undervaluation, nor any obvious reason to otherwise review the rates in the Architect's Award in this review process.

^Actual excerpt from ACA submission to Fair Work



Architects deserve a 22% pay rise so they are paid comparably to other similar professions

^UAW Campaign Position

UAW is the only organisation advocating for architectural workers, and we have real standing at Fair Work

The ACA tried to water down overtime - we successfully stopped them

Fair Work is asking whether architects need a pay rise - we think we need a 22% pay rise, and the ACA thinks we need nothing

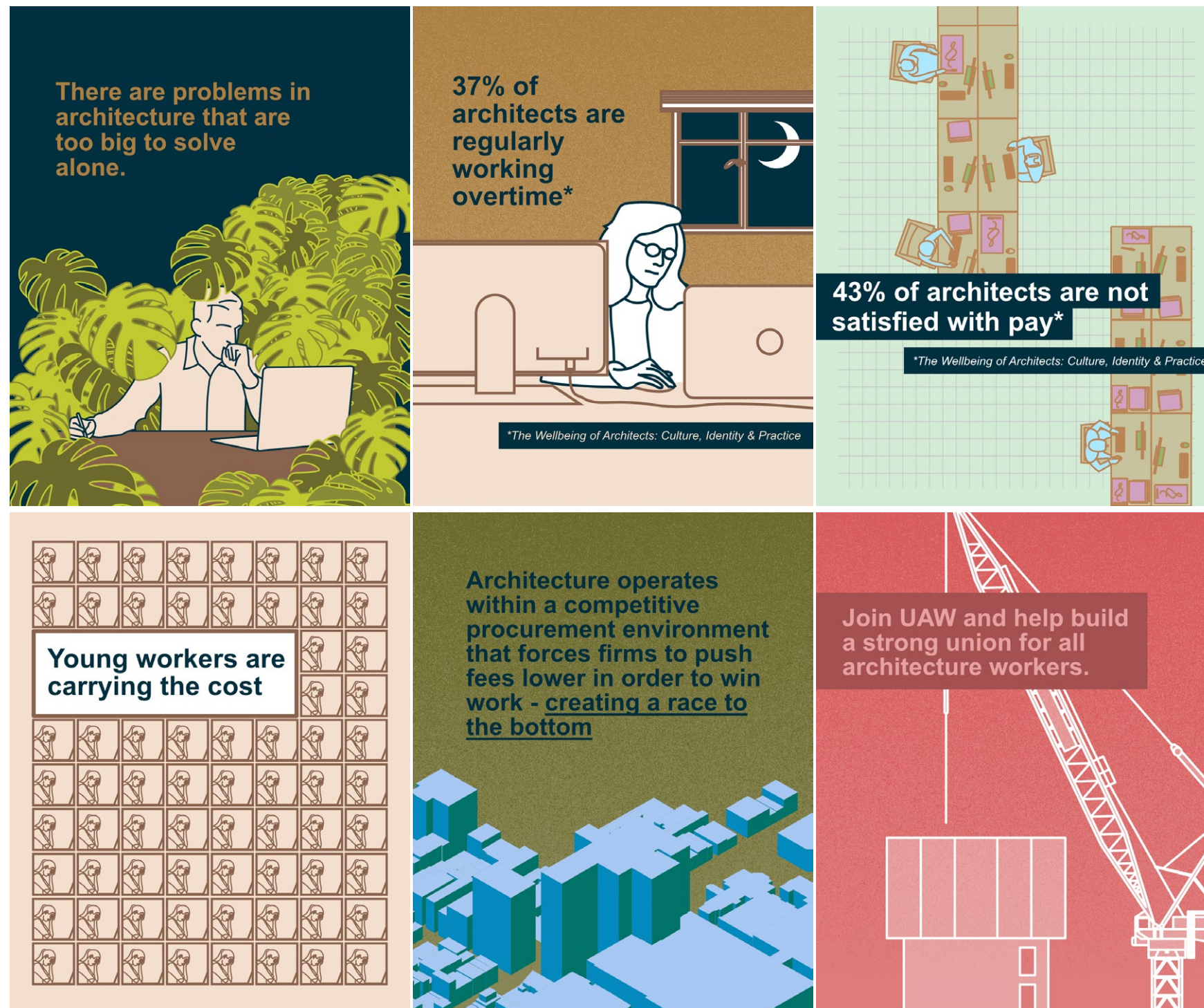


What can you do to make structural improvements in your workplace?

Join your union. Become an activist. Become a delegate. Organise your workplace

We also do larger scale organising and campaigning, like our Town Hall and Parlour Instagram collaboration

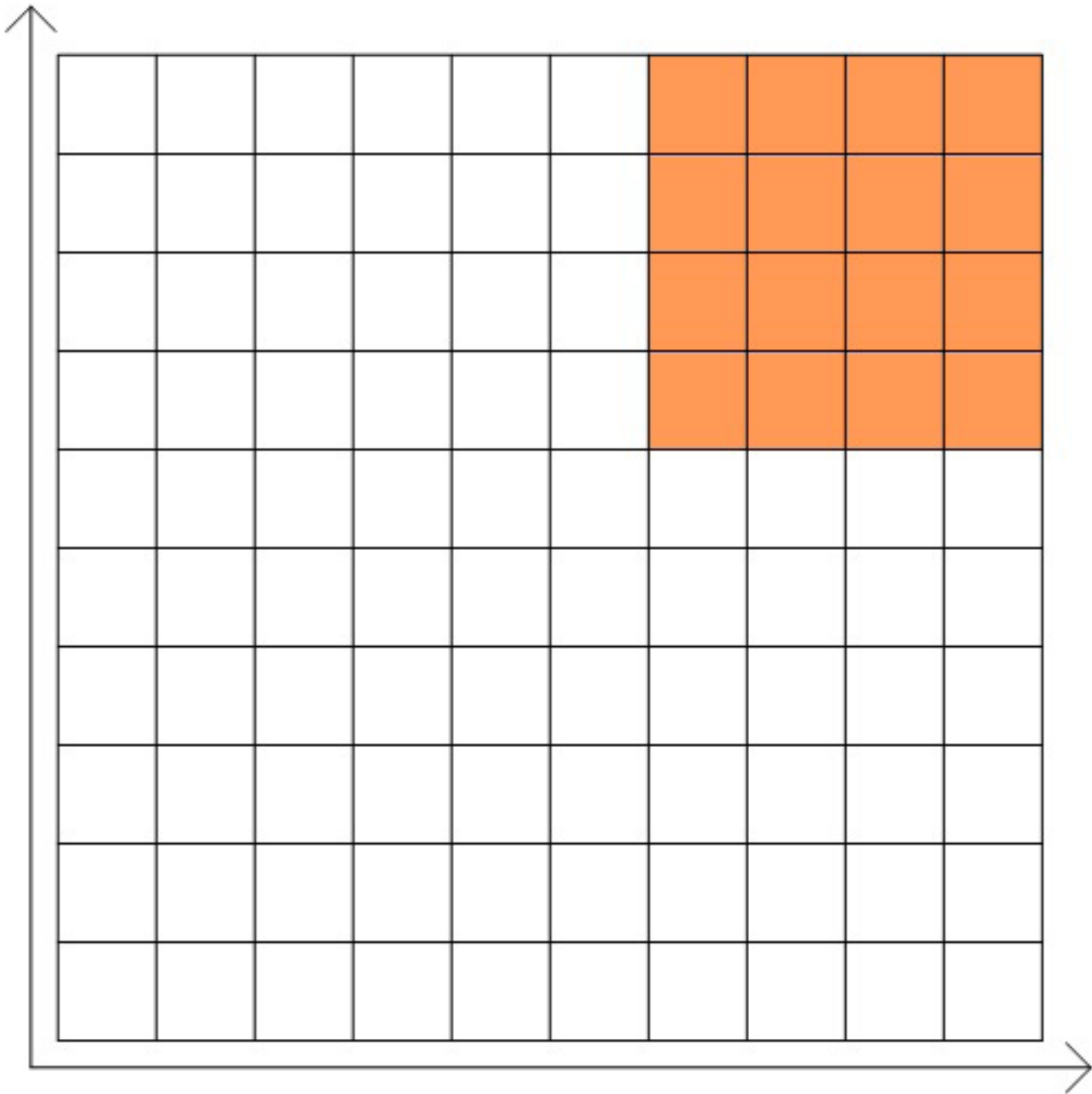
Organising



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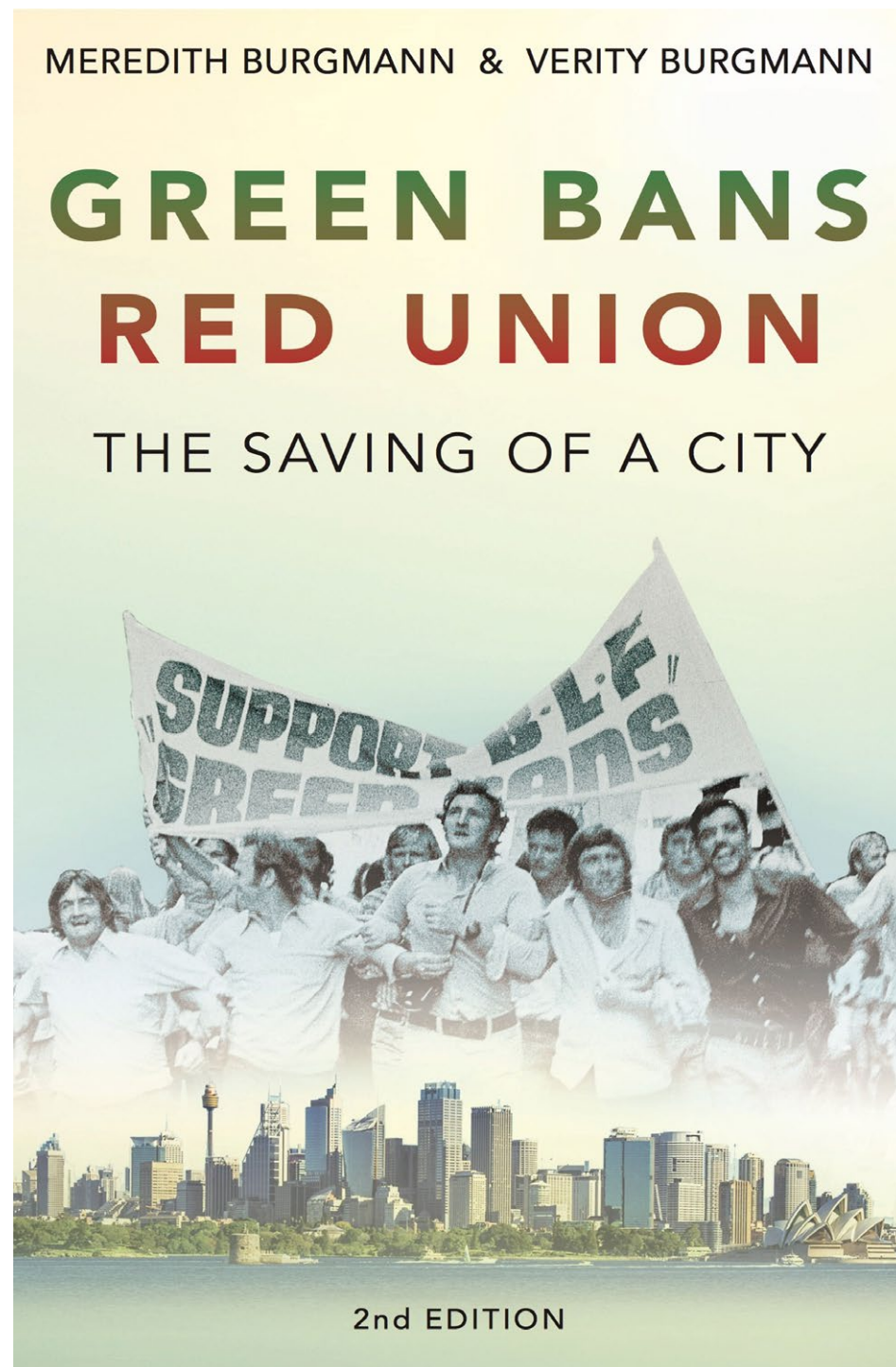
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As a delegate, you work out what issues affect the most people and how strongly they feel about them

If you have a majority of workers that want the same thing, your workplace must enter into collective bargaining with you

If you ask for the same reasonable things together, you are much more likely to create real change



Beyond collectively organised workplaces, much more is possible

Collectively owned businesses exist (most popular in France and Italy) - which is closer to real worker democracy

Once unions build enough power through density, they can start to set the agenda on other things we care about, like the Green Ban movement in the 70s

Collective Solutions to Common Problems

**There are problems in
architecture that are
too big to solve
alone.**



**Problems we've known
about for years.**

**Like unpaid overtime,
overwork, low pay,
burnout, & high pressure
that erode wellbeing &
drive people out of the
profession.**

Between 2020 and 2024, Australian researchers conducted one of the most comprehensive studies ever undertaken into wellbeing and work culture in architecture.*

The findings confirm what many workers already knew from experience.

**The Wellbeing of Architects:
Culture, Identity & Practice*

These problems are no longer anecdotal. They are systemic, measurable, and widespread.

To address them, we need collective solutions.

By organising together as workers, we can bargain for better conditions & reshape the culture of the profession.

**37% of
architects are
regularly
working
overtime***



**The Wellbeing of Architects: Culture, Identity & Practice*

***“The workloads are
extreme. There is an
expectation of unpaid
overtime”***

*Research participant,
The Wellbeing of Architects*

Unpaid overtime is wage theft.

Wage theft is unlawful.

The architect's award requires that overtime is paid at a penalty rate of 150%.

The Association of Consulting Architects (ACA) opposed the time-and-a-half provision for overtime in the award.*

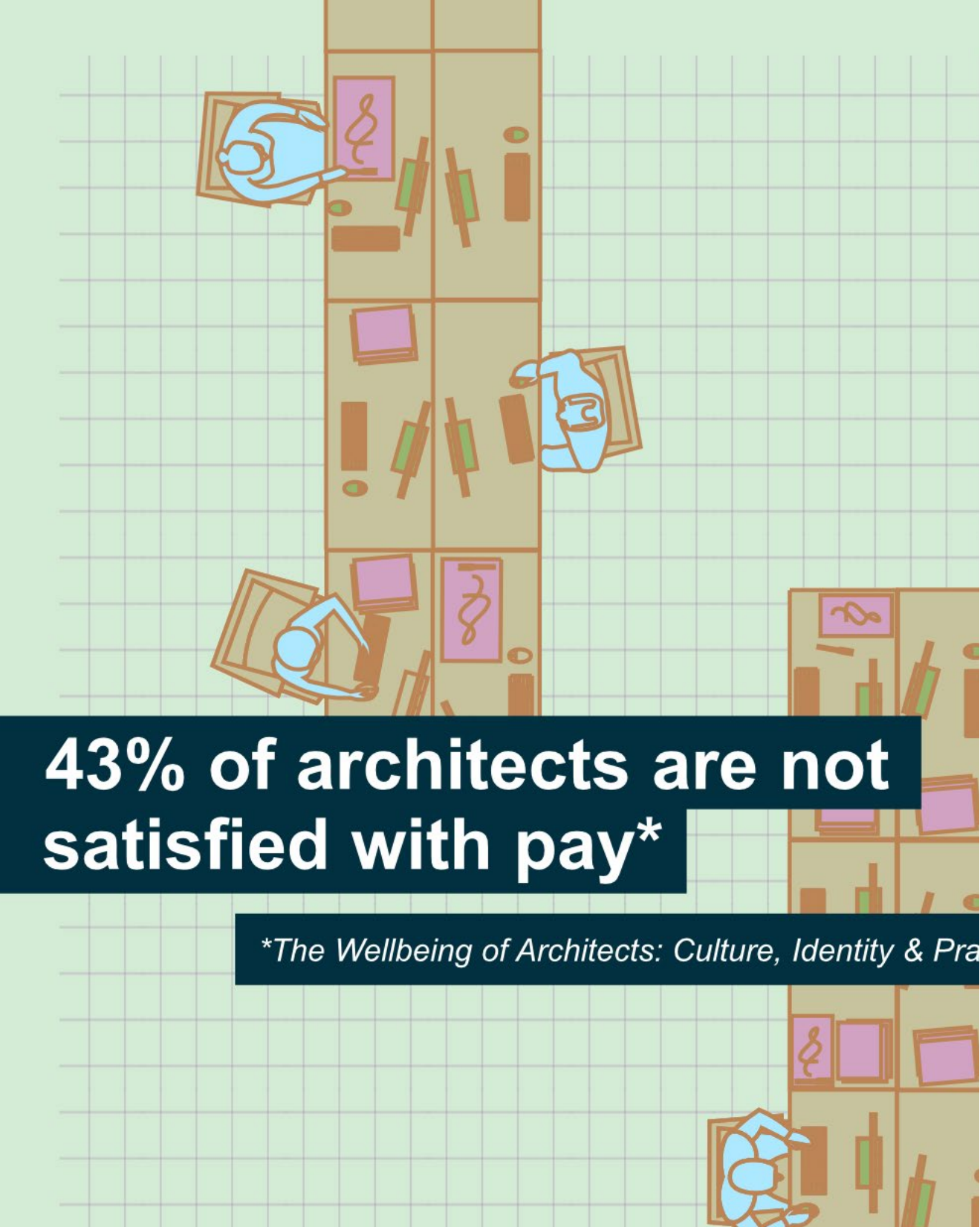
UAW intervened in the Fair Work process to defend the penalty rate for overtime.

**AM2014/257 Architects Award 2010
13 May 2016 Exposure Draft*

Your time is valuable.

**If you're fed up with
working unpaid
overtime, join UAW to
find out how you & your
colleagues can take
action.**





43% of architects are not satisfied with pay*

**The Wellbeing of Architects: Culture, Identity & Practice*

“Overall the real issue is time and money. We are not paid enough for our time.”

*Research participant,
The Wellbeing of Architects*

We deserve to be paid fairly for our labour and skill.

We can work together for a better deal.

Through the union, we can win stronger award protections, collective agreements, & transparent salary structures.

We know it works.

According to ABS data, unionised workers are paid 26% more than other workers, on average.

Union members had median weekly earnings of \$1,520 compared to \$1,208 for non-union members.

Median weekly earnings by income percentile Aug 2022

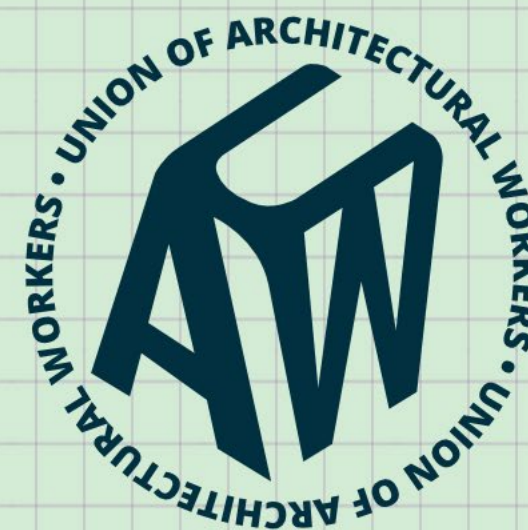


Being in a union delivers better wages across most industries



Industries with a high density of union membership are correlated with higher average salaries.

Join UAW & fight for better pay.





**Young workers are
carrying the cost**

***“There is a lack of
valuing the
contributions of
graduate & junior
architects”***

*Research participant,
The Wellbeing of Architects*

The research directly links under resourcing and low fees to the exploitation of younger workers.*

This isn't a rite of passage. It's an industrial issue.

**The Wellbeing of Architects
Culture, Identity & Practice*

Too many graduates enter the profession passionate about design, & quickly encounter burnout & financial insecurity.

The future of the profession depends on whether young workers can actually afford to stay in it.

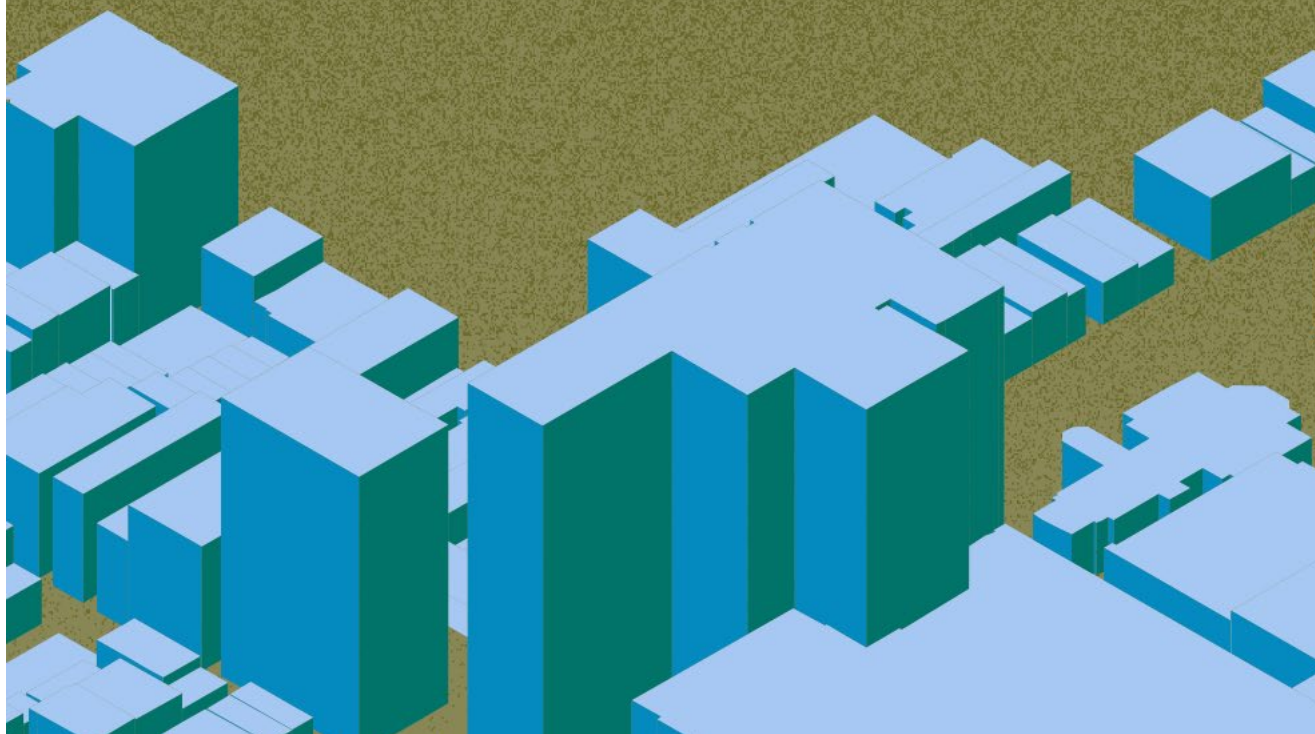
**UAW is currently
campaigning to raise
graduate award rates
by 20%.**

**Union membership is
free for students.**



STUDENTS

Architecture operates within a competitive procurement environment that forces firms to push fees lower in order to win work - creating a race to the bottom



*“Under-quoting and fee-cutting are an ever-present problem, often leading to low salaries and excessive workload”**

In other words, when projects are under-quoted, workers experience the impacts as exploitation.

**The Wellbeing of Architects
Culture, Identity & Practice*

“We as an entire profession need to stop the ‘race to the bottom’ with fee cutting and instead as an entire profession, charge appropriate fees for the work that we do”*

*Research participant,
The Wellbeing of Architects*

Individually, we can’t solve a race to the bottom that is structural.

But collective action can change the conditions of the industry through:

- **transparent fee-setting**
- **stronger award protections**
- **coordinated refusal of exploitative work**

The background of the image is a solid red color. Overlaid on this background is a white line drawing of a construction crane. The crane's lattice boom extends diagonally from the bottom right towards the top left. A vertical line representing a cable hangs from the crane's hook down to a rectangular building. The building is composed of several vertical sections. The text is positioned within a dark red rectangular area in the upper left portion of the image.

**Join UAW and help build
a strong union for all
architecture workers.**